

One quote from *The Grinch* has stuck with me as I think about consumerism and Christmas:

“Maybe Christmas,” he thought, “doesn’t come from a store. Maybe Christmas ... perhaps ... means a little bit more.”

—Dr. Suess¹²

While the Grinch isn’t only referring to gifts in his surprisingly profound thoughts, it reminds me that the best gifts are not ones that have to come from a retail shelf in a big box store. They can be creative and come from the heart too. Gourmet goodies, DIY hand scrubs, and other handmade items often hold the most meaning, and they can be pretty thrifty too!

The key to DIY gifts, though, is to start early. Every year I say I’m going to make my gifts for everyone, and then at the last minute I have to rush around trying to gather up ten different gift cards because I simply didn’t make time. Start a Pinterest board if you haven’t already for DIY gift ideas, then schedule some time each month to work on them.

I also don’t think you should be expected to buy, or make, a gift for everyone. Each Christmas, it seems like my own gift list gets larger, but there has to be a stopping point somewhere. Besides, Christmas isn’t about gifting, so keep the tradition as something special among immediate family members, and do a Secret Santa exchange with everyone else. This will keep the gifting cost down, and will be less stressful for everyone involved.

3. STOCK UP ON BAKING SUPPLIES

Every year starting in November, grocery stores discount almost all of their baking supplies—that means deeply discounted and stock up prices for us! One week it’s flour, the next it’s chocolate chips and cake mixes. Each week, take advantage of the sales and store extra ingredients wherever you have room.

Baking supplies usually last a long time, and since most of us use them all year ‘round, it makes sense to grab enough to last until Easter. That’s usually when the next round of baking supplies goes on sale.